

What air pollution does to women in India

People are travelling out of cities like Delhi to cleaner locations to **escape** the pollution that has **come to mark** North India's winters. Bans and other restrictions seem to have little effect as air pollution **soars** to dangerous levels. Crop **stubble** burning adds a **toxic** mix of **particulate matter** to the already polluted air. While everyone is affected, this pollution affects women more, especially pregnant women and their unborn children — **physiological** changes during pregnancy increase the chances of **adverse** impacts.

Studies show air pollution can cause **miscarriages**, **premature** birth, low birth weight, and poor **post-partum maternal** health. Many women have weakened respiratory systems from indoor air pollution — from cooking fuels like wood and dung — leaving them all the more **vulnerable** to outdoor air pollution. **Cardiovascular** diseases **exacerbated** by air pollution **manifest** differently in women who may not display the classic symptoms and, hence, do not get treatment on time, if at all. They are **compelled** to work outside, whether in agriculture or construction, and suffer **prolonged exposure** to the toxic air.

Though this has **hardly** been studied in the Indian context, high air pollution levels impact bone-density loss in post-menopausal women, as per researchers at Columbia University's Mailman School of Public Health. **Dr Surya Kant**, professor and head of the department of respiratory medicine, King George's Medical University, **says**, "Air pollution badly affects the health of women and the **foetus**. Air **pollutants** affect **intrauterine life** as they reach the foetus through the **placenta** and can cause growth **retardation**, death, **congenital** diseases and increase **susceptibility** to allergies, asthma, pneumonia, and tuberculosis."

A Chintan Foundation study showed that within a **cohort** of male and female safai karamcharis, women were six times more likely to have respiratory illness from air pollution. It is **imperative** to provide some amount of protection to women, especially pregnant and **lactating women**. Chintan suggests timely check-ups, nutritional supplements through government schemes, flexible working hours and access to resting places near workplaces. **Bharati Chaturvedi**, founder and director, Chintan Environmental Research and Action group, **says**, "Doctors have made it clear that women **bear** a greater **burden** of air pollution. But we never **acknowledge** that. Exposure to air pollution can **result in** premature babies and also lower birth rates. According to the WHO, low birthweight **infants** are about 20 times more likely to die than heavier infants. And later in life, they are more **susceptible** to **non-communicable diseases**. Who is the caregiver then? Obviously, women, at the cost of being able to earn, be economically independent and **hold onto** jobs. Those with **modest** means suffer the most because their access to health care, support with **child rearing** and access to nutrition is low. At a time when India is trying to better female labour force participation, limiting women's exposure to polluted air can give the next generation and our economy a better chance. According to the development

consulting group Dalberg's research, air pollution costs India \$95 billion in **productivity**. Perhaps we can reduce this bill by protecting women by seeing this crisis through a gendered **lens**."

There is little awareness that women are differently and dangerously affected by air pollution. The government should **factor** this **into** its policies and schemes. The **heartening** though **incremental** **rise** in the number of women in the labour force **should** not be **stymied** by the adverse health impacts of pollution. India's cities are among the most polluted in the world and this is now affecting the next generation in the form of young and unborn children as well. [Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Lens** (noun) – Standpoint, perspective, viewpoint, दृष्टिकोण

Vocabulary

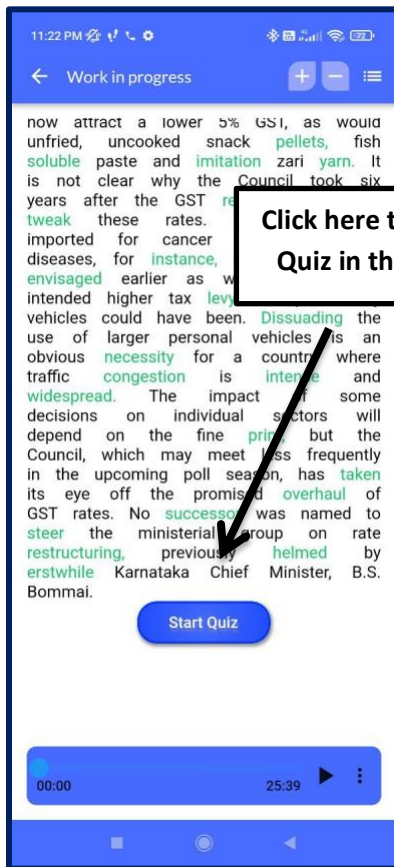
1. **Escape** (verb) – Avoid, get away from, flee, evade, elude बचना
2. **Come to mark** (phrase) – To become characteristic of; to be notable for का प्रतीक बनना
3. **Soar** (verb) – Rise rapidly, increase sharply, surge, escalate, skyrocket बढ़ना
4. **Stubble** (noun) – Crop residue, leftover stalks, straw remains पराली
5. **Toxic** (adjective) – Poisonous, harmful, noxious, venomous, hazardous विषैला
6. **Particulate matter** (noun) – Tiny particles suspended in the air that can be harmful when inhaled सूक्ष्म कण पदार्थ
7. **Physiological** (adjective) – Bodily, physical, biological, relating to body functions शारीरिक
8. **Adverse** (adjective) – Harmful, unfavorable, detrimental, negative, injurious प्रतिकूल
9. **Miscarriage** (noun) – Pregnancy loss, spontaneous abortion, loss of fetus गर्भपात
10. **Premature** (adjective) – Early, untimely, before full term, too soon असमय
11. **Post-partum** (adjective) – After childbirth, following delivery, postnatal प्रसवोत्तर
12. **Maternal** (adjective) – Motherly, relating to motherhood, parental मातृ संबंधी
13. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – Susceptible, exposed, defenseless, at risk संवेदनशील
14. **Cardiovascular** (adjective) – Relating to the heart and blood vessels हृदय संबंधी
15. **Exacerbate** (verb) – Worsen, aggravate, intensify, heighten बिगाड़ना
16. **Manifest** (verb) – Display, exhibit, show, reveal, demonstrate प्रकट होना
17. **Compel** (verb) – Force, oblige, necessitate, coerce मजबूर करना
18. **Prolonged** (adjective) – Extended, lengthy, protracted, drawn-out दीर्घकालिक
19. **Exposure** (noun) – Contact, experience, vulnerability संपर्क
20. **Hardly** (adverb) – Barely, scarcely, almost not, only just मुश्किल से
21. **Foetus** (noun) – Unborn baby, embryo, developing infant भ्रूण
22. **Pollutant** (noun) – Contaminant, impurity, toxin, harmful substance प्रदूषक
23. **Intrauterine life** (noun) – The period of development within the uterus गर्भाशय के अंदर का जीवन

24. **Placenta** (noun) – An organ that connects the developing fetus to the uterine wall to allow nutrient uptake गर्भनाल
25. **Retardation** (noun) – Delay, slowing down, hindrance विलंब
26. **Congenital** (adjective) – Inborn, hereditary, innate, existing from birth जन्मजात
27. **Susceptibility** (noun) – Vulnerability, sensitivity, proneness संवेदनशीलता
28. **Cohort** (noun) – Group, category, set, class समूह
29. **Imperative** (adjective) – Essential, crucial, necessary, urgent अत्यावश्यक
30. **Lactating women** (noun) – Women who are producing milk and breastfeeding दूध पिलाने वाली महिलाएं
31. **Bear the burden of** (phrase) – Carry the weight, endure responsibility, shoulder भार उठाना
32. **Acknowledge** (verb) – Recognize, admit, accept, concede स्वीकार करना
33. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, cause, bring about, produce का परिणाम होना
34. **Infant** (noun) – Baby, newborn, toddler शिशु
35. **Susceptible** (adjective) – Vulnerable, prone, liable, sensitive संवेदनशील
36. **Non-communicable disease** (noun) – Chronic diseases not passed from person to person, such as heart disease गैर-संचारी रोग
37. **Hold onto** (phrasal verb) – Keep, retain, maintain बनाए रखना
38. **Modest** (adjective) – Limited, small, moderate, humble साधारण
39. **Child rearing** (noun) – The process of bringing up and caring for children बच्चों का पालन-पोषण
40. **Productivity** (noun) – Efficiency, output, performance उत्पादकता
41. **Factor into** (phrasal verb) – Include, consider, incorporate, take into account को ध्यान में रखना
42. **Heartening** (adjective) – Encouraging, uplifting, reassuring, inspiring प्रोत्साहनजनक
43. **Incremental** (adjective) – Gradual, progressive, step-by-step क्रमिक
44. **Stymie** (verb) – Hinder, obstruct, impede, thwart बाधा डालना

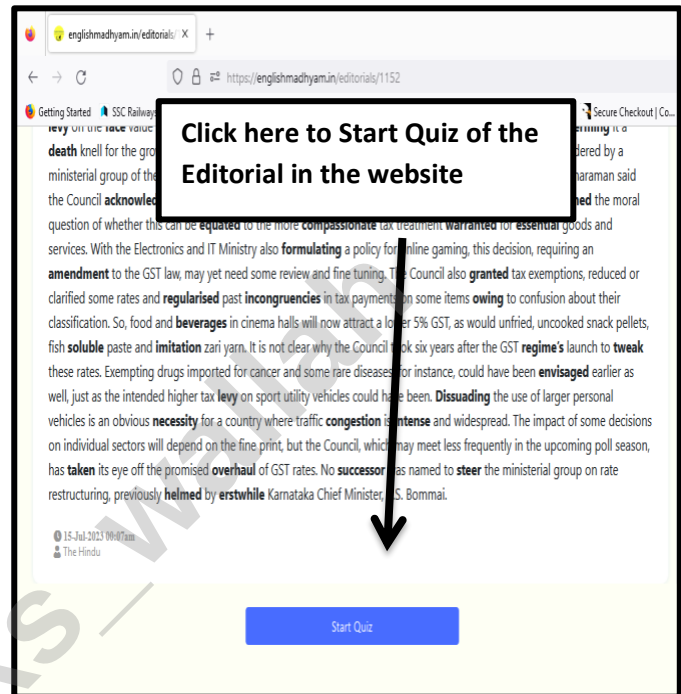
Summary of the Editorial

1. Many people are leaving polluted cities like Delhi in search of cleaner air during North India's harsh winter pollution.
2. Current bans and restrictions have limited impact, while stubble burning continues to worsen air pollution.
3. Women, especially pregnant ones, are more vulnerable to air pollution due to physiological changes during pregnancy.
4. Air pollution in India is linked to higher risks of miscarriages, premature births, low birth weights, and poor maternal health.
5. Indoor air pollution from cooking fuels like wood and dung has weakened many women's respiratory systems.
6. Women often do not receive timely treatment for cardiovascular diseases linked to air pollution due to different symptoms from men.
7. Many women work outdoors in sectors like agriculture and construction, facing prolonged exposure to harmful pollutants.
8. Research shows that air pollution also contributes to bone-density loss in post-menopausal women.
9. Air pollution has adverse effects on intrauterine life, causing growth retardation, congenital diseases, and higher risk of respiratory ailments in children.
10. Female safai karamcharis are more likely to suffer respiratory illnesses from air pollution compared to their male counterparts.
11. Protective measures such as regular health check-ups, better nutrition, and flexible work arrangements are necessary, especially for pregnant and lactating women.
12. Women often bear the economic and caregiving burdens of pollution, affecting their economic independence and employment.
13. Low birthweight infants are at a greater risk of mortality and future non-communicable diseases, affecting women disproportionately.
14. Women with limited resources suffer more due to restricted access to healthcare, nutrition, and child-rearing support.
15. Addressing air pollution through a gendered perspective could enhance female labor force participation and boost economic productivity.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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